Personal Statement

Irene Berezin | 43769694

The first thing I nearly accomplished at UBC was leaving it. In October of my first year, all of my midterms came back between 50 and 60 percent, and I was looking up flights home, how to withdraw from my degree, and how much money I had wasted coming here. By November, I had lost 25 pounds, and every day was filled with terror. I didn't yet know that what I was fighting had a name—Generalized Anxiety Disorder.

With treatment and support from the Centre for Accessibility, I began to recover, but mentors helped me find my footing. Three years later, I am one of eight students in the Honours Economics program, and I have tried to become the same mentors that supported me in first year. As Editor-in-Chief of IONA, UBC's undergraduate economics journal, I teach over 40 junior students how to critically analyze economic research. I am launching a graduate school mentorship program for women in economics and the social sciences. I also mentor with AGORA and the Undergraduate Research Opportunities club, and volunteer as a peer tutor at the VSE.

Late in my first and second year, I got my first taste of research helping redesign UBC's economics curriculum around the machine learning tools social scientists now use. Concurrently, I joined a project on how Canada's public health officials were treated online during COVID-19, where we found that trusted experts were driven out of public conversation, with misinformation filling that gap.

In my third year, my team took home the second win of the Bank of Canada Governor's Challenge for UBC. The Bank then hired me as one of three summer researchers. Canada's mortgage rules decide which families can buy a home, meaning policymakers need to balance protecting families and access to housing. To help the Bank predict the effects of changes in mortgage rules, I measured the effects of past ones by having a computer read decades of financial news. I presented this work to economists across the Bank, and it now forms the basis of a paper with two Bank economists.

My Honours Thesis uses game theory to tackle one of the most pressing problems in the next few decades—the problem of AI alignment. AI systems are quickly taking on high-consequence work, where a system pursuing even slightly wrong goals can cause irreversible harm, making alignment with human intent important. If AI systems can tell when they are being tested, our safety tests tell us very little. Game theory, the mathematics of strategic decisions, was built for this kind of problem. My thesis applies game theory to AI. I treat the developer and the AI system as two players, and work out how often, and in what form, developers should run surprise tests so that behaving well at all times becomes the AI's best strategy.

Next, I plan to complete a Master's in Computer Science at UBC and then a PhD in economics, with the goal of furthering this alignment research.

STATEMENT OF ACTIVITIES

Personal Information

Irene Berezin | iberez01@student.ubc.ca | Student No. 43769694

Academic Achievements and Education

B.A., Honours Economics, University of British Columbia *(Sep 2023 – May 2027, expected)* — 90% average; one of eight students admitted to Honours. Thesis: Game theory for AI alignment.

Master's Scholarship Award for Women in Economics & Finance, Bank of Canada *(Mar 2026)* — $10,000 award.

Trek Excellence Scholarship (x2), UBC *(Aug 2024, Aug 2025)* — Top 5% of year and faculty.

Governor's Challenge – National Winner, Bank of Canada *(Sep 2025 – Jan 2026; 10 hrs/wk)* — Beat 27 university teams, UBC's second win. Forecasted inflation in Canada and how tariffs would raise prices in each of the 10 provinces; presented to senior Bank leaders.

University Activities

Editor-in-Chief and Senior Editor, IONA Journal of Economics *(Oct 2025 – present; 6 hrs/wk)* — Lead UBC's undergraduate economics journal (Best Economics Club Award, 2025/26) and 40 students to read and judge research. Launching a mentorship program to help women in economics and the social sciences reach graduate school.

Research Assistant, Prof. Jonathan Graves, Economics *(Feb 2024 – May 2026; 5 hrs/wk term, 20–40 hrs/wk summer)* — Ran workshops teaching 200+ students to use AI in their research. Used AI to read 3,000+ pages of 19th-century BC Supreme Court rulings and measure racial bias in judges' reasoning.

Research Assistant, Prof. Ying Gao, Economics *(May 2026 – present; 10 hrs/wk)* — Proved results for a paper on how long platforms like YouTube should try out new creators, and how that shapes creators' effort.

Research Assistant, Prof. Laura Nelson, Sociology *(Jun 2024 – Sep 2025; 10 hrs/wk)* — Analyzed 8 million tweets and uncovered large-scale harassment campaigns against Canadian public health officials during COVID-19.

Community & Volunteer Services

Mentor, AGORA Economics Mentorship; Undergraduate Research Opportunities *(Sep 2026 – present; 3 hrs/wk each)* — Help first- and second-year students start research or find research positions.

Volunteer Peer Academic Tutor, Vancouver School of Economics *(Sep 2025 – present; 2 hrs/wk)* — Tutor students in economics, statistics, and math.

Athletics

Backcountry Skiing & Mountaineering, Varsity Outdoor Club *(Sep 2023 – present; 5 hrs/wk)* — Lead ski-touring and alpine mountaineering trips.

Other Activities

Research Assistant, Financial Stability Department, Bank of Canada *(May 2026 – present; 40 hrs/wk summer, 5 hrs/week now.)* — One of three undergraduates hired. Built a new way to measure the effects of Canada's mortgage rules, such as the mortgage stress test, by having a computer read decades of Canadian financial news. Presented to economists across the Bank; now the basis of a paper.